



PA Wilds Resource Center

Helping revitalize communities through sustainable tourism development

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Resources and Tutorials

How do I apply for a grant?

For better or worse, there is no one way to write a grant. Some weigh in at five pages. Others might take a hundred. Sometimes the money comes with few strings attached. Other grants require matching funds, or require the recipient to do things like hire union contractors or “buy American.”

Still, there are some general guidelines. This page aims to answer some of the questions that new grant writers frequently ask, or at least point you to resources that answer them. It also has links to established tutorial programs—some that you can go through free of charge—giving you a sense of what a grant application looks like, how to write a good description of your project... everything down to how you should bind an application that you have to submit in hard copy.

Before we get into the details and the links, it probably makes sense to lay out a few facts to help get you started.

- There are so many grants that it generally makes sense to break them down into different categories. One popular method is to divide grants into Federal Grants, State Grants, Local Grants and Foundation Grants.
- For the purposes of this website, we have broken them into National, State and Regional/Local. Each category includes both government grants and private grants.
- There are no hard and fast rules, but here are some generally accepted grant-writing guidelines:
 - As far as government grants go, federal grants are generally the most competitive.
 - Federal grants often require more paperwork than state and local grants. They are also more likely to come with strings attached, such as union and “buy American” provisions.
 - Applying for a federal grant usually requires an organization to acquire a “DUNS Number.” Getting one is a free and straight-forward process, described at www.grants.gov/applicants/request_duns_number.jsp
 - State grants do not typically require a DUNS number, but Pennsylvania’s DCNR grants currently has a line requesting one, although offering the information is optional.

Workshops, Tutorials and Technical Assistance

The Conservation Fund

A national leader in nonprofit conservation efforts, the Conservation Fund also offers a series of training and education courses for community and corporate leaders, known as the Conservation Leadership Network. A list of upcoming courses, (for which participants pay a fee) is available here.

DCED

The Pennsylvania Department of Community and Economic Development offers a wealth of resources to help communities take advantage of various funding opportunities. The best overview of these resources is [available here](#). Of particular interest are links to these resources, taken directly from the site:

- **Funding** – Learn more about the two Land Use Planning and Technical Assistance Programs (LUPTAP). The first program includes the Community Planning and Implementation Programs. The second program includes planning studies for Transit Revitalization Investment Districts (Act 238 of 2004) (Internal link to - Planning Studies Program (TRID)). Funding supports multi-municipal, regional and county planning and implementation efforts. Access the [LUPTAP and TRID Guidelines](#). (updated 2/5/08)
- **Publications** – Access the [Municipalities Planning Code \(MPC\)](#), the Governor's Center's popular [Planning Series](#) of publications, planning and land use reports such as the State Land Use and Growth Management Report 2005, Better Models for Development in Pennsylvania, Pennsylvania Standards for Residential Site Development, and Suggested Provisions to Meet the requirements of the [National Flood Insurance Program \(NFIP\)](#). (updated 4/11/07)

- Technical Assistance – Learn more on how local government officials can [request assistance](#) from the Center on land use and planning issues. Or find out about the National Flood Insurance Program (NFIP).
- Training – Access the Center's [training database](#) and calendar. You can also access the Center's MPC Made Easy [workshop](#) online.

The site offers a host of other resources, including extremely valuable compilations of state land-use regulations and other important documents.

Northern Tier Cultural Alliance

[The Northern Tier Cultural Alliance](#) regularly offers grant-writing workshops, specifically for Pennsylvania Partners in the Arts “Project Stream,” during May and June. The workshops last about an hour and will cover the grant cycle, eligibility, restrictions and overall grant writing suggestions. For more info on Pennsylvania Partners in the Arts, see the Local and Regional Sources section of [Where to Look for Funding](#). For more info on the NTCA workshops, visit: <http://www.ntculturalalliance.org/ppa.html>

The Pennsylvania Historical and Museum Commission

PHMC is in the process of scheduling the Fall series of grant workshops to assist organizations with the preparation of PHMC grant applications. The workshops provided an overview of the grant program, upcoming changes to the program, eGrant instructions and the opportunity to meet with all of the PHMC grant program managers. If you cannot attend a workshop, PHMC encourages you to contact a grant program manager to discuss your potential project. You may also download a [pdf version \(2 MB file size\) of the Grant Workshop presentation](#) and a [pdf version \(464 Kb file size\) of the eGrant instruction presentation](#) for an overview of the program.

DCNR Regional Services Division

The Department of Conservation and Natural Resources (DCNR) manages a variety of grant and technical assistance programs concerned with community recreation, heritage areas, river conservation, greenways and trails, and natural areas and open space under the Bureau of Recreation and Conservation.

Regional Recreation and Park Advisors provide technical assistance and information to communities, nonprofit groups, regional organizations, and government agencies in their geographic locale; regional staff is your first point of contact. Clients in these areas are assisted through the grant program with advice, direction, consultation, technical materials, and referral services provided by their regional office.

- Region 4 - Northcentral / Williamsport Regional Office
(Cameron, Centre, Clinton, Columbia, Lycoming, Montour, Northumberland, Potter, Snyder, Tioga, & Union Counties)
Contacts: Wes Fahringer (570) 326-3521
- Region 6 - Northwest / Erie Regional Office
(Clarion, Clearfield, Crawford, Elk, Erie, Forest, Jefferson, Lawrence, McKean, Mercer, Venango, & Warren Counties)
Contact: Kim McCullough (814) 217-9009
- Grants Projects Management
Contacts: Greg Gove, (717) 783-2662; Vacant – Acquisition Projects, (717) 772-3742; Cindy Dunlap– Planning Projects, (717) 783-6705; Alex Tatanish – LWCF (717) 783-4735 This division directs programs to provide grants to local governments, municipal authorities, and nonprofit organizations for community and regional projects. Such activities include the planning, acquisition, rehabilitation and development of public park, recreation and conservation areas, facilities, programs, recreational trails, rivers, blueways and greenways. Programming is also done in collaboration with zoo organizations to assist in the development and/or rehabilitation of public zoological parks.
- Greenways and Conservation Partnerships
Contacts: Diane Kripas, (717) 772-1282; Vanyla Tierney– Greenways and Rivers Partnerships, (717) 783-2654; Mike Eschenmann – Community Recreation Partnerships, (717) 783-2360 This division provides professional consultations and assistance to local governments, municipal authorities, and nonprofit organizations to help develop and implement community and regional projects. Consultations and assistance are also provided to groups implementing heritage conservation programs. Such programs work to enhance, preserve, and promote natural, recreational, cultural and scenic resources for heritage conservation, tourism, and economic development.
- Planning, Outreach, and Technical Support
Contacts: Darrel Siesholtz, (717) 783-2661; Pamela Stouffer– Contracting and Payments, (717) 783-4122; Linda Manning, Planning and Technical Assistance 717-783-4736 From determining application periods to preparing the grant notification letters to processing of payments through project close out, this division works to execute the grant process smoothly and efficiently. The development of workshops, bulletins, publications, newsletters and other educational materials assist in the dissemination of the technical information associated with the grant process. Other major responsibilities found in this program area include the development and maintenance of the Statewide Comprehensive Outdoor Recreation Plan and the Statewide Greenways Plan.

The Foundation Center

[The Foundation Center](#) is a national organization that offers training for fundraisers. Some in-person seminars, like the Grantseeker Training Institute, cost up to \$800 and last five days. Others, such as the Proposal Writing Basics course, are free. One of the best resources is a FREE online tutorial that offers a great introduction to first-time grant-writers. [Click here](#). For a list of all Foundation Center courses, click [here](#).

The Grantsmanship Center

[The Grantsmanship Center](#) has been offering grant-writing workshops since 1972. These are extensive training programs, offered across the country, that last as long as a week. They cost approximately \$900. The next workshop in Pennsylvania is at Robert Morris University near Pittsburgh. For more information, click [here](#).

A Guide to Funding Resources from the USDA Rural Information Center

This is an absolutely indispensable link for people just getting started. In addition to numerous online databases, it provides web links to more than 60 full-text online guides, manuals, and tips. Visit <http://www.nal.usda.gov/ric/ricpubs/fundguide.html>.

Just a few of the resources pointed out this excellent site:

- *Basic Elements of Grant Writing*. Corporation for Public Broadcasting. <http://www.cpb.org/grants/grantwriting.html>
- *A Condensed Version of Proposal Planning and Writing*. Jeremy T. Miner, Lynn E. Miner.
<http://www.minerandassociates.com/PPW3 Brief.htm>
- *Developing and Writing Grant Proposals*. Catalog of Federal Domestic Assistance.
http://12.46.245.173/pls/portal30/CATALOG.GRANT_PROPOSAL_DYN.show
- *EPA Grant-Writing Tutorial*. U.S. Environmental Protection Agency. <http://www.epa.gov/seahome/grants.html>

Grant Seeker's Guide to the Galaxy

Tons of really basic stuff, but it's a great place to start for people who are just beginning. [Click here](#).

Finally, for federal government help on how to begin, [click here](#).